

LIVE

NEWSPAPER

EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

19TH APRIL 2017



1

Lines of defence

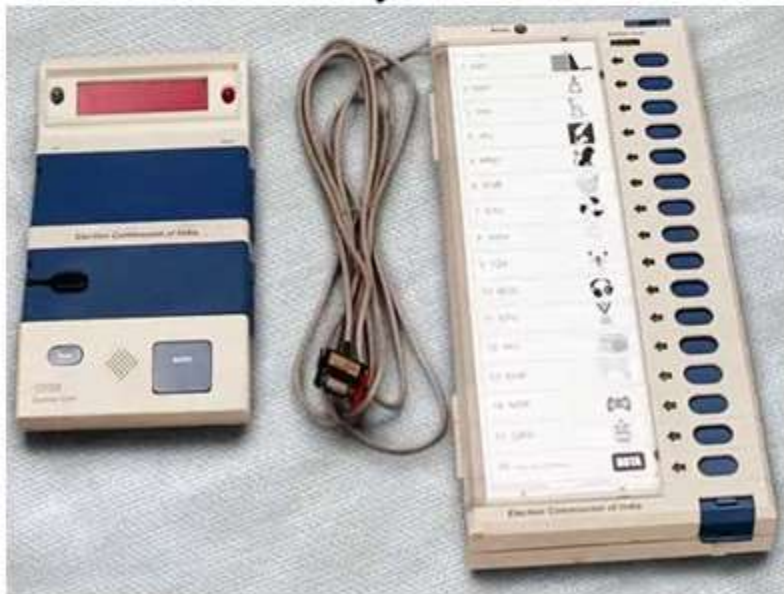
The inclusion of paper audit trails to the EVMs is costly but perhaps unavoidable

In the face of extreme and unreasonable complaints against Electronic Voting Machines by a number of political parties, the Election Commission perhaps had no choice but to have the working of the machines corroborated by a paper audit trail. To have such a facility ready for all constituencies by the 2019 Lok Sabha election is expensive (an estimated ₹3,174 crore) and also unnecessary (paper trails are at best required in a few constituencies to corroborate results). Its request to the Law Ministry to release funds for the procurement of voter-verifiable paper audit trail (VVPAT) machines for the 2019 Lok Sabha election should be interpreted in this context. As many as 16 lakh VVPAT machines will be required and only an urgent release of funds will allow the machines to be ready in time for 2019. It was possible for the EC to brush off the complaints from the Bahujan Samaj Party and the Aam Aadmi Party following their defeat in Uttar Pradesh and Punjab respectively, but it clearly became increasingly difficult for it to ignore the clutch of parties that joined the chorus, some demanding a return to paper ballots.

The EC has repeatedly assured voters that there are enough procedural and technical safeguards to prevent large-scale tampering or manipulation of EVMs. Since 2006, elections have witnessed the use of upgraded EVMs – Model 2 machines, with security features such as dynamic ending of key codes on ballot units and their transfer as messages to the control unit in an encrypted manner. EVMs feature encoded software that is burnt one-time on to programmable chips, enabling them to be used as stand-alone machines rather than computer-connected units, thus preventing any hacking by remote devices. Model 3 machines produced after 2013 have additional features such as tamper detection. The EC has laid down procedural rules of locking and storing EVMs before and after polling, besides functional checks and tests in the presence of representatives of political parties. The addition of the VVPAT machine to the process is to allow for cross-checking of EVM results through a paper audit, completing another layer of accountability to the indigenously produced machines (only the microchip is manufactured outside the country with the machine language embedded on it). Contrary to glib claims about tampering, studies show the introduction of EVMs has resulted in a drastic reduction in electoral fraud (rigging, stuffing of ballot boxes, etc.) and allowed for greater voter participation. Since reverting to the older paper ballot system will be regressive, the only option in the face of the protests is to have a back-up in the form of a paper trail – something that will hopefully put a quietus to the controversy.

THE  HINDU

Date : 19th April, 2017





NEWS REPORT



- 1 The Election Commission has asked for the early release of funds for the procurement of Voter-Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) machines for the 2019 Lok Sabha election.
- 2 16 lakh VVPAT machines will be required.
- 3 An urgent release of funds will allow the machines to be ready in time for 2019.
- 4 This assumed significance as more and more parties that joined the chorus are demanding a return to paper ballots.





MODEL 2 MACHINES



- 1 Since 2006, elections have witnessed the use of upgraded EVMs.
- 2 Model 2 machines, with security features such as dynamic coding of key codes on ballot units and their transfer as messages to the control unit in an encrypted manner.
- 3 EVMs feature encoded software that is burnt one-time on to programmable chips.
- 4 It enables them to be used as stand-alone machines rather than computer-connected units.
- 5 Hence, any hacking by remote devices is prevented.



MODEL 3 MACHINES

- 1 These are produced after 2013 and have additional features such as tamper detection.
- 2 There are procedural rules of locking and storing EVMs before and after polling.
- 3 Besides, functional checks and tests in the presence of representatives of political parties is also incorporated.



NOW VVPAT MACHINES

This allows for cross-checking of EVM results through a paper audit, completing another layer of accountability and these are indigenously produced machines.

Only the microchip is manufactured outside the country with the machine language embedded on it.



WHY REVERSAL TO PAPER BALLOTS IS NOT ADVISABLE?

- 1 In the days of paper ballots, electoral fraud in the form of rigging, stuffing of ballot boxes, etc. were common features.
- 2 Introduction of EVMs allowed greater voter participation.
- 3 Reverting to the older paper ballot system will be regressive

Hence, the only way out is a back-up in the form of a paper trail.



2

Equity in debt

The expert panel's recommendation to review the fiscal responsibility law is timely

The advice of the expert committee to review the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act of 2003 requires attention, given India's track record. This is all the more so given the born-again political conviction that promises of random largesse to voters is just fine. Excessive and unsustainable borrowing by the government is obviously perverse as it entails a cost on future generations while crowding out private investment. In the past, fiscal irresponsibility has cost jobs, spiked inflation, put the currency in a tailspin and even brought the country to the brink of a default. The possibility of default may have resulted in the liberalisation of the economy in 1991, but the key trigger was irrational public spending on borrowed money in the late-1980s. Less than a decade later, with fiscal discipline faltering and the deficit shooting up to 10% of GDP, the FRBM law was enacted to 'limit the government's borrowing authority' under Article 268 of the Constitution. But the target to limit the fiscal deficit to 3% of GDP (by 2009) was abandoned after the 2008 global financial crisis as a liberal stimulus reversed the gains in the fiscal space, creating fresh macro-level instability. The FRBM Act's deficit target is now only likely to be met next year.

Such damage transmissions from the political economy to the real economy need to be checked forthwith. The committee's proposal to maintain the 3% target till 2019-20 before aiming for further reduction is pragmatic, as the 'extraordinary and unanticipated domestic development' of demonetisation happened during its tenure. Such an event, the committee has said, could trigger an escape clause from fixed fiscal targets in its proposed rule-based framework. Instead of focusing purely on the fiscal and revenue deficit numbers, which should be brought down to 2.5% and 0.8% of GDP

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N K SINGH COMMITTEE ... HISTORY OF FRBM ACT

- 1 FRBM Act was formulated in 2003.
- 2 It kept fiscal deficit target of 3% of GDP.
- 3 But it was thrown to winds after 2008 financial crisis.
- 4 Even 2017-18 budget kept the fiscal deficit target of 3.2% of GDP with the commitment of 3% by 2018-19.
- 5 Excessive fiscal deficit will threaten the macro economic stability.



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WHAT IS THE PROBLEM WITH MORE FISCAL DEFICIT?

- 1 It will put unnecessary costs on future generations.
- 2 It crowds out private investment.
- 3 The fiscal irresponsibility may cost jobs.
- 4 Inflation may take place.
- 5 Domestic Currency may be affected.
- 6 Countries may go towards the default situation.

The basic problem is irrational public spending on borrowed money. If the borrowed money is used for creation of assets, then there should not be any problem.

REVENUE EXPENDITURE

“These are short term expenses to meet the ongoing operating costs of running a business i.e., operating expenses”.





CAPITAL EXPENDITURE (CAPEX)

“It is the Expenditure to acquire / upgrade buildings or equipment.

This expenditure is for the acquisition of long term assets”.



CAPITAL EXPENDITURE



REVENUE EXPENDITURE



CAPITAL EXPENDITURE



REVENUE EXPENDITURE





CAPITAL EXPENDITURE



REVENUE EXPENDITURE





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WHY THE GOVERNMENT HAS GONE FOR N. K. SINGH COMMITTEE?

- 1 Government could not achieve 3% fiscal deficit target even after 14 years of passage of FRBM Act.
- 2 Government feels that more money can be borrowed to give boost to the economy and the 3% stipulation, sometimes is coming in the way to achieve desired growth.
- 3 Government should have leverage to decide what is best for the country.



WHAT ARE N K SINGH COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATIONS?

- 1 Overall it stipulates the public debt as the main anchor.
- 2 By 2023, public debt must be limited to 60% of GDP.
- 3 It should be 40% for Center and 20% for States.
- 4 Overall at present, it is 68% of GDP.
- 5 In the interim time, the fiscal deficit targets can be fixed as 3% by FY20 and 2.5% by FY23.
- 6 There will be an escape clause up to 0.5% deviation in case of extraordinary and unanticipated domestic developments.
- 7 Fiscal Council should be created with independent experts that could sit in judgement on the need for deviations from the targets.

Overall Government should move fast to implement N K Singh committee recommendations.

3 Lonely and disinterested

Excess focus on bilateralism is leaving India isolated in its larger neighbourhood



HAPPINESS JACOB

Picture this: China is steadily increasing its geostrategic presence in South, Central and West Asia; there is a China-Russia-Pakistan axis on the rise in Southern Asia; China and Russia are revealing in a new-found rapprochement and aim to fill the geopolitical vacuum bound to be created by the U.S. withdrawal from the region; and, a retired Pakistan army chief is all set to take over as the first Commander-in-Chief of the Saudi-backed Islamic Military Alliance (IMA). Now ask yourself: Which regional power has been missing from these significant developments on the regional geopolitical landscape?

New Delhi's foreign policy establishment and its national security team are either clueless about what is happening in its broader neighbourhood or seem to lack the wherewithal to anticipate, engage and shape geostrategic outcomes in the region and beyond. Or are they simply disinterested? Either way, New Delhi is increasingly looking like a grumpy old man constantly whining about age-old fears, stubbornly unwilling to explore new opportunities and face new challenges.

China-Russia-Pakistan axis

Alliances are natural to international politics and friend-enemy binaries and historical hesitations are often cast aside when such alliances take shape. While China and Pakistan have been allies since the 1960s, China and the Soviet Union weren't the best of friends during the Cold War, nor did they have a great relationship in the post-Soviet days. Pakistan and the Soviet Union were Cold War rivals, and Russia did not, until recently, share a close relationship with Pakistan. All that is changing now, with them



ganging up to undo American dominance in the region, among other things.

The Afghan reconciliation process is a major focus of this new partnership. In a December 2015 meeting in Moscow, they highlighted the importance of seeking a "flexible approach" to dealing with the Afghan Taliban. This is over and above their ongoing individual engagements with the various parties to the Afghan conflict.

Clearly, this new axis of a resurgent Russia, ambitious China and opportunistic Pakistan, in combination with other related developments, will not only diminish U.S. power in the region but could also potentially constrain Indian influence. Sino-Russian relations, through joint military exercises and the Russian sale of advanced weaponry to China, for instance, could hurt India's strategic options globally.

Beijing has traditionally been a reluctant dealmaker, preferring to stick to business instead. Of late, it has overcome this pragmatic inhibition, first by joining the Afghan peace process and now increasingly focusing on West Asia. In a sense, its engagement in regional conflicts is a logical extension of its One Belt, One Road (OBOR) project. Having committed huge sums to the project, Beijing realises that some of its inherent political risks should be reduced by engaging in regional conflict resolution processes, a lesson well learnt from the playbook of great power diplomacy.

Both China and Russia have been

active in the West Asian theatre, having vetoed U.S.-sponsored sanctions against Syria, they believe that it is necessary to nudge the warring Syrian factions to negotiate. Beijing has also been reaching out to and balancing the various adversaries in the region such as Israel, Saudi Arabia and even Iran, and increasingly talking the language of reconciliation. Also, recall while New Delhi buckled under pressure from Washington to take sides on Iran, Beijing refused to do so.

Compared to the thornier West Asia, engaging South Asia is easier for China given that the smaller countries in the region see it as an infrastructure provider, with deep pockets and without the usual moral science lessons. Bangladesh, one of India's close allies in the region, is likely to attend the OBOR summit in May and may even sign up for it. Chinese interest in Afghan reconciliation stems not only from a security/terrorism angle but also more significantly to ensure the sustainability of OBOR given its importance in providing access to Central Asia.

Russian U-turns

Make no mistake, Russia is looking beyond a reluctant India in South Asia: President Vladimir Putin has no time for diplomatic subtleties and tales about the long history of Indo-Russian relations, ignoring Indian sensitivities. Moscow has gone ahead with forging strategic ties with Islamabad: from lifting the arms embargo, selling weaponry, discussing the future of Afghanistan, to joint military exercises.

When Russia formally joins OBOR, it will have indirectly taken a position on Kashmir which is not necessarily in keeping with the Indian stand on the issue. If the Russian envoy's remarks at the Heart of Asia conference in December are anything to go by, Moscow is also taking a pragmatic stand on terrorism in South Asia.

The Pakistan pivot

The "global outcast", Pakistan is today an inevitable henchman of Southern Asian geopolitics. In a world of realpolitik, norm regress and opportunistic bandwagoning, Pakistan is the new regional favourite. Whether we like it or not, now that Pakistan's generals have waited out the Americans and NATO from Afghanistan, the outcomes of the Afghan conflict will largely be determined by Rawalpindi. This fits well with the Chinese and Russian regional grand strategies. Gone are the days when Islamabad was currying favour with Washington; today, Moscow and Beijing are actively courting it. Normative considerations apart, it is in this sense of the big picture that prevents Beijing from acting against Pakistan-based terror groups; irritating India is a side benefit.

For sure, Pakistan has consistently used terrorism as a tool of statecraft, and yet there is a recognition today that it is a pivotal state in addressing terror. Moreover, while the IMA is still in its infancy, we need to look closely at its potential. Will it emerge, even though it is at a moment an overwhelmingly Sunni sectarian force, as a potent regional military alliance in the years to come? What role would Pakistan play in this "Islamic NATO"? What implications would it have for India?

Head-in-the-sand approach

Amidst such geopolitical reshaping of the region, New Delhi has done precious little to counter them or to propose a collective regional future. The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC),

which should have been the central plank of India's "neighbourhood first" policy, is in doldrums today. Having jettisoned SAARC and unwilling to promote other regional initiatives, institutional or issue-based, India continues to prefer unilateralism towards neighbours. The shortcomings of bilateralism in a world hungry for institutions and structures should be evident to us.

The External Affairs Ministry's reactive diplomacy – its unfading institutional hallmark – is unable to see the wood for the trees in its relations with Beijing. How does, for instance, designating Masood Azhar a terrorist become India's core interest vis-à-vis China? Should we allow a terror-monger to determine our relationship with one of our biggest trading partners?

While it is true that the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor will pass through Pakistan-controlled territory that India has claimed, we should find a via media with China on the issue rather than publicly dismiss the initiative. Given that OBOR is a futuristic mega-project, its benefits as well as cross-national and inter-continental linkages, all of which would eventually bypass India, will only become clearer in the years to come. To base our analysis on current cost-benefit calculations in terms of immediate returns and short-term sustainability is missing the big picture. Moreover, our ability to create regional infrastructural arrangements, excluding China and Pakistan, remains limited. In short then, a few decades down the line, India could end up far more isolated: the logical conclusion of an inward-looking political class.

It's time New Delhi focused on the big picture and avoided paralytic positions while addressing the emerging fault lines on the global geopolitical landscape.

Happiness Jacob is Senior Global Challenges Fellow, Global Public Policy Institute, Berlin, and Associate Professor of Disarmament Studies, School of International Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University



3

Lonely and disinterested

Excess focus on bilateralism is leaving India isolated in its larger neighbourhood



HAPTEMON JACOB

Picture this: China is steadily increasing its geostrategic presence in South, Central and West Asia; there is a China-Russia-Pakistan axis on the rise in South Asia; China and Russia are revelling in a new-found rapprochement and aim to fill the geopolitical vacuum bound to be created by the U.S. withdrawal from the region; and, a retired Pakistani army chief is all set to take over as the first Commander-in-Chief of the Saudi-backed Islamic Military Alliance (IMA). Now ask yourself: Which regional power has been missing from these significant developments on the regional geopolitical landscape?

New Delhi's foreign policy establishment and its national security team are either clueless about what is happening in its broader neighbourhood, or seem to lack the wherewithal to anticipate, engage and shape geostrategic outcomes in the region and beyond. Or are they simply disinterested? Either way, New Delhi is increasingly looking like a grumpy old man constantly whining about age-old fears, stubbornly unwilling to explore new opportunities and face new challenges.

China-Russia-Pakistan axis

Alliances are natural to international politics and friend-enemy binaries and historical hostilities are often cast aside when such alliances take shape. While China and Pakistan have been allies since the 1960s, China and the Soviet Union weren't the best of friends during the Cold War, nor did they have a great relationship in the post-Soviet days. Pakistan and the Soviet Union were Cold War rivals, and Russia did not, until recently, share a close relationship with Pakistan. All that is changing now, with them



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The Afghan reconciliation process is a major focus of this new partnership. In a December 2016 meeting in Moscow, they highlighted the importance of seeking a "flexible approach" to dealing with the Afghan Taliban. This is over and above their ongoing individual engagements with the various parties to the Afghan conflict.

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The 'global outreach', Pakistan is today an inevitable lynchpin of Southern Asian geopolitics. In a world of realpolitik, norm regress and opportunistic handwringing, Pakistan is the new regional favourite. Whether we like it or not, now that Pakistan's generals have waived out the Americans and NATO from Afghanistan, the outcomes of the Afghan conflict will largely be determined by Islamabad. This fits well with the Chinese and Russian regional grand strategies. Gone are the days when Islamabad was currying favour with Washington; today, Moscow and Beijing are actively courting it. Normative considerations apart, it is this sense of the big picture that prevents Beijing from acting against Pakistan-based terror groups; irritating India is a side benefit.

For sure, Pakistan has consistently used terrorism as a tool of statecraft, and yet there is a recognition today that it is a pivotal state in addressing terror. Moreover, while the IMA is still in its infancy, we need to look closely at its potential. Will it emerge, even though it is at a moment an overwhelmingly Sunni sectarian force, as a potent regional military alliance in the years to come? What role would Pakistan play in this 'Islamic NATO'? What implications would it have for India?

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anistan, to joint military exercises. The 'global outreach' policy, which should have been the central plank of India's 'neighbourhood first' policy, is in doldrums today. Having jettisoned SAARC and unwilling to promote other regional initiatives, institutional or issue-based, India continues to prefer unilateralism towards neighbours. The shortcomings of bilateralism in a world hungry for institutions and structures should be evident to us.

The External Affairs Ministry's reactive diplomacy - its unfailing institutional hallmark - is unable to see the wood for the trees in its relations with Beijing. How does, for instance, designating Masood Azhar a terrorist become India's core interest vis-à-vis China? Should we allow a terror-monger to determine our relationship with one of our biggest trading partners?

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It's time New Delhi focussed on the big picture and avoided paralytic positions while addressing the emerging fault lines on the global geopolitical landscape.

Head-in-the-sand approach

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WHAT IS HAPPENING IN 21ST CENTURY?

- 1 China is increasing its geostrategic presence in South, Central and West Asia.
- 2 China-Russia-Pakistan axis is on the rise.
- 3 US appears to be withdrawing from the region.
- 4 A Retd. Pakistan Army Chief is going to take over as the first Commander-in-Chief of Saudi Arabia backed Islamic Military Alliance

THE  HINDUDate : 19th April, 2017

Under these circumstances, why India is sitting silent?

WESTERN ASIA

RUSSIA





SOUTH ASIA

IRAN

AFGHANISTAN

PAKISTAN

INDIA

NEPAL

BHUTAN

CHINA

BANGLADESH

SRI LANKA

MALDIVES

Yemen

OMAN

Arabian Sea

Bay of Bengal



CENTRAL ASIA





CHINA – RUSSIA – PAKISTAN AXIS





ACTIONS OF CHINA & RUSSIA



- 1 Both the countries are taking active role in geopolitics of West Asia.
- 2 China felt that to take OBOR to the logical conclusion, it has to involve in the regional conflict resolution processes.
- 3 China changed its strategy of concentrating only on business to involving in the geopolitics of the area.
- 4 China is reaching out and balancing various adversaries in the region such as Israel, Saudi Arabia and Iran.



CHINA – INDIA – SOUTH ASIA

**1**

AFGHANISTAN ISSUE

- *China joined the Afghanistan Peace Process.*
- *Chinese interests in Afghan reconciliation, not only because of security or terrorism angle, but more significantly to ensure the sustainability of OBOR, given its importance in providing access to Central Asia.*

CENTRAL ASIA



CHINA – INDIA – SOUTH ASIA



2

SRI LANKA ISSUE

- *If we look at Sri Lanka issue, Chinese presence is already there in Hambantota port.*
- *It is going to develop Colombo port city project and ultimately it will establish its naval base at Hambantota in the years to come.*



CHINA – INDIA – SOUTH ASIA

**3**

MALDIVES ISSUE

- *Chinese presence in Maldives is quite deep. It is taking up several infrastructure projects, at the same time, in future it may take some of the islands on long lease from Maldives.*

CHINA – INDIA – SOUTH ASIA



4

BANGLADESH ISSUE

- *Bangladesh is at present closest ally of India.*
- *All this may change once the committed investment of billions of dollars flows into the Bangladesh.*
- *Bangladesh is also going to attend OBOR Summit scheduled in the month of May in China and it may sign the initiative also.*



CHINA – INDIA – SOUTH ASIA

**5**

PAKISTAN ISSUE

- *CPEC is already becoming a reality and Pakistan will become one of the closest ally of China in the years to come and Gwadar port may become one more naval base for China.*



CHINA – INDIA – SOUTH ASIA

6

NEPAL ISSUE



- Geographically Nepal is well connected to India and accessing China is difficult for Nepal.
- Even though it tried several times to get access from China, but because of geographical constraints it is still dependent on India.
- But in the near future, when the connectivity to Tibet is extended to Nepal, the situation may change in the years to come.



RUSSIA - PAKISTAN

- 1** *Russia is going ahead with forging strategic ties with Pakistan.*
- 2** *It lifted the arms embargo and is selling weapons.*
- 3** *It is discussing future of Afghanistan with Pakistan and it is doing joint military exercises.*
- 4** *When Russia formally joins OBOR, then it will put Russia on the side of Pakistan over the Kashmir issue.*
- 5** *If that happens, India's historical relations with Russia may go down.*



LOOK AT PAKISTAN



- 1** *Pakistan in spite of its credentials of aiding and abetting terrorists both towards India and Afghanistan, is becoming the key country in South Asia geopolitics.*
- 2** *It is becoming regional favourite for both China and Russia.*
- 3** *This bond between Russia-Pakistan, China-Pakistan, which is called as China-Russia-Pakistan axis is going to be strengthened in near future.*



IS INDIA BECOMING ISOLATED?

- 1** SAARC is almost inactive.
- 2** We have not promoted regional institutions, we are only discussing the issues independently with various countries.
- 3** China's economic might is all around us and which may translate into strategic alliances with various countries in our neighbourhood.
- 4** We have bent upon Masood Azhar for so long to designate him as a terrorist and we are not able to look beyond that.
- 5** Tomorrow CPEC is becoming a reality and then Pakistan will become regional player in spite of its dubious distinction of promoting terrorism.
- 6** With the billions of dollars in our adjacent countries along with CPEC as well as imminent China-Russia-Pakistan axis, where are we heading for?

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HAPPPEMON JACOB

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ganging up to undo American dominance in the region, among other things.

The Afghan reconciliation process is a major focus of this new partnership. In a December 2016 meeting in Moscow, they highlighted the importance of seeking a "flexible approach" to dealing with the Afghan Taliban. This is over and above their ongoing individual engagements with the various parties to the Afghan conflict.

Clearly, this new axis of a resurgent Russia, ambitious China and opportunistic Pakistan, in combination with other related developments, will not only diminish U.S. power in the region but could also potentially constrain Indian influence. Sino-Russian relations, through joint military exercises and the Russian sale of advanced weaponry to China, for instance, could hurt India's strategic options globally.

Beijing has traditionally been a reluctant dealmaker, preferring to stick to business instead. Of late, it has overcome this pragmatic inhibition, first by joining the Afghan peace process and now increasingly focussing on West Asia. In a sense, its engagement in regional conflicts is a logical extension of its One Belt, One Road (OBOR) project. Having committed huge sums to the project, Beijing realises that some of its inherent political risks should be reduced by engaging in regional conflict resolution processes, a lesson well learnt from the playbook of great power diplomacy.

Both China and Russia have been

active in the West Asian theatre. Having vetoed U.S.-sponsored sanctions against Syria, they believe that it is necessary to nudge the warring Syrian factions to negotiate. Beijing has also been reaching out to and balancing the various adversaries in the region such as Israel, Saudi Arabia and even Iran, and increasingly talking the language of reconciliation. Also, recall while New Delhi buckled under pressure from Washington to take sides on Iran, Beijing refused to do so.

Compared to the thornier West Asia, engaging South Asia is easier for China given that the smaller countries in the region see it as an infrastructure provider, with deep pockets and without the usual moral science leasos. Bangladesh, one of India's close allies in the region, is likely to attend the OBOR summit in May and may even sign up for it. Chinese interest in Afghan reconciliation stems not only from a security/terrorism angle but also more significantly to ensure the sustainability of OBOR given its importance in providing access to Central Asia.

Russian U-turn

Make no mistake, Russia is looking beyond a reluctant India in South Asia: President Vladimir Putin has no time for diplomatic subtleties and tales about the long history of Indo-Russian relations. Ignoring Indian sensitivities, Moscow has gone ahead with forging strategic ties with Islamabad, from lifting the arms embargo, selling weaponry, discussing the future of Afgh-

anistan, to joint military exercises.

When Russia formally joins OBOR, it will have indirectly taken a position on Kashmir which is not necessarily in keeping with the Indian stand on the issue. If the Russian envoy's remarks at the Heart of Asia conference in December are anything to go by, Moscow is also taking a pragmatic stand on terrorism in South Asia.

The Pakistan pivot

The 'global outcast', Pakistan is today an inevitable lynchpin of Southern Asian geopolitics. In a world of realpolitik, norm regress and opportunistic handwagging, Pakistan is the new regional favourite. Whether we like it or not, now that Pakistan's generals have waived out the Americans and NATO from Afghanistan, the outcomes of the Afghan conflict will largely be determined by Rawalpindi. This fits well with the Chinese and Russian regional grand strategies. Gone are the days when Islamabad was currying favour with Washington; today, Moscow and Beijing are actively courting it. Normative considerations apart, it is this sense of the big picture that prevents Beijing from acting against Pakistan-based terror groups; irritating India is a side benefit.

For sure, Pakistan has consistently used terrorism as a tool of statecraft, and yet there is a recognition today that it is a pivotal state in addressing terror. Moreover, while the IMA is still in its infancy, we need to look closely at its potential. Will it emerge, even though it is at a moment an overwhelmingly Sunni sectarian force, as a potent regional military alliance in the years to come? What role would Pakistan play in this 'Islamic NATO'? What implications would it have for India?

Head-in-the-sand approach

Amidst such geopolitical reshaping of the region, New Delhi has done precious little to counter them or to propose a collective regional future. The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC),

which should have been the central plank of India's 'neighbourhood first' policy, is in doldrums today. Having jettisoned SAARC and unwilling to promote other regional initiatives, institutional or issue-based, India continues to prefer unilateralism towards neighbours. The shortcomings of bilateralism in a world hungry for institutions and structures should be evident to us.

The External Affairs Ministry's reactive diplomacy - its unflinching institutional hallmark - is unable to see the wood for the trees in its relations with Beijing. How does, for instance, designating Masood Azhar a terrorist become India's core interest vis-à-vis China? Should we allow a terror-monger to determine our relationship with one of our biggest trading partners?

While it is true that the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor will pass through Pakistan-controlled territory that India has claimed, we should find a via media with China on the issue rather than publicly dismiss the initiative. Given that OBOR is a futuristic mega-project, its benefits as well as cross-national and inter-continental linkages, all of which would eventually bypass India, will only become clearer in the years to come. To base our analysis on current cost-benefit calculations in terms of immediate returns and short-term sustainability is missing the big picture. Moreover, our ability to create regional infrastructural arrangements, excluding China and Pakistan, remains limited. In short then, a few decades down the line, India could end up far more isolated: the logical conclusion of an inward-looking political class.

It's time New Delhi focussed on the big picture and avoided paralytic positions while addressing the emerging fault lines on the global geopolitical landscape.

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Probably 10 to 20 years down the line, India may become isolated and we may be forced to toe the line of the predominant powers in the region and by that time it would be too late to become regional power on our own!

4 After the referendum

Turkey feels more and more socially divided, and Recep Erdoğan may not govern to unify



VIJAY PRASHAD

Turkey is a fundamentally divided society. The vote this weekend over a referendum to give the President additional powers and a longer term, showed the extent of Turkey's divisions. The "Yes" vote, a victory for President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, was won with 25 million votes, while the "No" campaign fetched almost 24 million votes. But given the nature of electoral democracy, a fractured verdict will nonetheless mean an expansion of the powers of Mr. Erdoğan and of his ruling Justice and Development Party (AKP). The referendum amends the 1982 Constitution with some significant provisions, such as making the President both the head of state and the head of government, weakening Parliament, the judiciary and the military. Mr. Erdoğan could remain in power – virtually unchallenged – till 2029. Society's divisions will not be reflected in the political sphere.

The AKP, and its far-right ally, the Nationalist Movement Party (MHP), had hoped to commandeer close to

two-thirds of the vote in order to make these changes legitimate. They were not able to get near this margin. Turkey's three largest cities – Istanbul, Ankara and İzmir – voted decisively against the changes. It was rural and small-town Turkey that delivered the votes for the "Yes" campaign. These areas, located in remote parts of Anatolia, have long been neglected by the Istanbul elite and have for the past two decades seen the AKP as their champion. Personal piety is not their only link to the agenda of the AKP, which has pushed against the barriers of Turkey's official secularism. A great deal of pent-up resentment against urban affluence is wrapped up in the support for Mr. Erdoğan, who speaks in the idiom of the small town.

Unleashing repression

But this support base was insufficient during two parliamentary elections in 2015, when Mr. Erdoğan hoped to push these changes through a friendly Parliament. Since the Peoples' Democratic Party (HDP) – a Kurdish and Left alliance – won over 10% of the vote, it was able to stymie Mr. Erdoğan's plans. What followed after that defeat set the terms for significant political repression. Mr. Erdoğan's government declared that the HDP was linked to terrorism, opened up



a war against the largely Kurdish southeast of Turkey with the displacement of over 200,000 people and imposed endless curfews on major towns. Visitors to the Turkish city of Diyarbakır might be tempted to make comparisons with the flattened cities of Syria's Aleppo and Iraq's Fallujah. HDP politicians have been imprisoned, with both their leaders, Selahattin Demirtaş and Figen Yüksekdağ, facing hundreds of years in prison.

A failed coup on July 15, 2016 deepened the repression by the state. It was blamed on the U.S.-based Turkish cleric Fethullah Gülen. Almost 100,000 people have been arrested since that coup, and over 100,000 state employees fired from their posts. The purges (*tasfiye*) have not only denuded Turkish society of trained and capable people but have also chilled the atmosphere in the country. Gloom is the mood amongst large parts of the

urban population, which has not experienced this kind of open harassment since the coups d'état of 1971 and 1980. It was as if this failed coup had an aftermath as anti-democratic as the successful coups of Turkey's past.

Curbing democratic processes

It was apparent during the campaign over this referendum that Mr. Erdoğan would prevail. Society is not united behind him, but the state apparatus came into great use. Opposition leaders were arrested – 122 HDP leaders by their count. Campaigners for the "No" vote were accused of being part of the Gülen plot. In the largely Kurdish province of Siirt, the provincial governor banned the HDP's song "Say No" on the pretext that it would incite "public hate". The popular cartoonist, Musa Kart, spent a hundred days in jail, while Turkey's most respected constitutional law expert, İbrahim Kaboğlu, lost his job. With 150 media outlets shut down and almost 200 journalists arrested, press scrutiny of these manoeuvres was minimal. Democracy was already curtailed before the referendum. Critics of Mr. Erdoğan warn that Turkey is under "tek adam" rule – one-man rule.

Turkey's High Electoral Board chief Sadı Güven announced that the referendum had passed despite

the numerous complaints of fraud. The Opposition moved the board to reconsider the 1.5 million ballots that raised eyebrows. The margin of victory was only 1.1 million. Intimidation of voters was general. Even supporters of Mr. Erdoğan who had decided to vote "No" – such as editor, Yeni Şafak, and columnist Ali Bayramoğlu – were beaten on polling day. The government dominated the media and prevented the Opposition from making its case against the referendum.

#HayırDahaBitmedi is the new hashtag on social media. "It is not over yet". There is great expectation from half of those who voted that the President must not be allowed to rule as if he has a mandate. No wonder that Mr. Erdoğan's victory speech was uncharacteristically subdued. His Prime Minister, Binali Yıldırım, said of the result: "We are one body. We are one nation." But it did not feel like that. Turkey feels more and more socially divided. Mr. Erdoğan will not govern to unify. That is not his style. His policies – like that of other Strong Men in the Age of Anger – will more ferociously tear at the social fabric of this fine country.

Vijay Prashad's most recent book is *"The Death of the Nation and the Future of the Arab Revolution"*. He is a columnist for the Turkish daily, *BirGün*.

THE  HINDU

Date : 19th April, 2017



ROMANIA

RUSSIA

Black Sea

BULGARIA

GEORGIA

Bosphorous Strait

Ankara

TURKEY

Istanbul

Sea of Marmara

Dardanelles

Aegean Sea

Greece

ALBANIA

MACEDONIA (FYROM)

SERBIA

HUNGARY

CROATIA

AZERBAIJDAN

SYRIA

IRAQ

Mediterranean Sea

Cyprus

Lebanon

AT A GLANCE

- Official ... Republic of Turkey
- Major ... Anatolian Peninsula
- Minor ... Balkan Peninsula
- It is successor to the Ottoman Empire
- Republic of Turkey established on 29th Oct, 1923.
- First President... Kemal Ataturk
- Early member of NATO
- Capital ... Ankara
- Largest city ... Istanbul
- Official language ... Turkish
- Largest minority group ... Kurds
- Currency ... Turkish Lira
- HDI ... 0.761 (high)
- Per capita Nominal GDP ... \$ 9,562
- Predominantly Sunni Muslim



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a war against southern placemen and important city of Diyarbakir. A failed deepened state. It based on the Gülen. A been over 100 from the five) have society people b mospher the mood

AGAIN ELITES VS REMOTE AREAS

- 1 Elites vs remote areas gap is widening across the world.
- 2 This is the third example. Previously Brexit as well as the victory of Donald Trump were primarily due to the support, they got from the rural/interior areas but not from the Elites. Now the referendum in Turkey in favour of more powers for the Presidency is also because of rural and small-town Turkey.
- 3 These areas, located in remote parts of Anatolia, have long been neglected by the Istanbul elite.
- 4 A great deal of pent-up resentment against urban affluence came in favour of Erdoğan.

**IS TURKEY HEADING TOWARDS AUTHORITARIAN REGIME?**

- 1** At present, endless curfews are imposed in major towns, where Kurdish are in majority.
- 2** After the failed coup on July 15, 2016 several people have been arrested and over 1,00,000 state employees fired from their posts.
- 3** Several journalists were arrested.
- 4** Several restrictions were imposed on the people, who were canvassing for NO vote.
- 5** The fabric of Turkey was widely divided with 25 million people voting Yes and 24 million people voting No.
- 6** The style of Mr. Erdoğan will further widen the divisions in the Turkish society.
- 7** As the time passes, there is every possibility that Erdoğan may go in further authoritarian way.

If Mr. Erdoğan happens to be in power till 2029 then, Turkey will be just like another West Asian country, where authoritarianism is prevalent.



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